Task 5 : Cybercrime Awareness Case Study & Prevention guide

Chosen Cybercrime Type: UPI/Online Payment Fraud

UPI/Online Payment Fraud is a widespread cybercrime in India where scammers illegally drain money from victims' bank accounts using the fast UPI payment system. Criminals rarely hack accounts directly instead, they use social engineering to trick people into revealing sensitive details.

Priya Sharma, a 28 year old software engineer from Bhopal, received a call from a person claiming to be from Swiggy customer care. He said there was a problem with her recent food order and needed to process a refund. Trusting the caller, Priya shared the last four digits of her registered mobile number. When an OTP arrived, she read it aloud. Within minutes, scammers transferred ₹68,000 from her account through multiple quick UPI transactions.

The typical process involves:

(1) Gathering basic details through phishing SMS or fake calls,

(2) Posing as customer support or delivery agents,

(3) Tricking victims into sharing OTPs or UPI PINs, and

(4) Instantly moving funds via mule accounts.

Young professionals, senior citizens, and small traders are commonly targeted due to their regular UPI usage. Consequences include sudden financial loss, emotional trauma, loss of trust in digital payments, and lengthy battles with banks and police for recovery. In 2024–25, such frauds caused massive losses across India. Immediate reporting to 1930 or cybercrime.gov.in is crucial, but prevention through awareness remains the best protection.